

The Best Laid Plans

"Introducing first... fighting out of the red corner and representing *Rampage Sports, Incorporated*... from Oakland, California... she is... Zen-DAY-AH COLLLLLLE-MAN!"

Daya came out, with Steph and Marcy right behind, as usual. But Z's choice of Emily VanCamp as the final member of her supporting cast came as a surprise to me. No explanation had been offered, nor did I ask for one. This is what Daya wanted, and Em was more than up to the task. That was all I needed to know.

Being the most well-known of our rookie trio, Z earned a decent pop from the assembled masses as she made her entrance. But it was nothing compared to what we all knew was coming.

"And now... introducing her opponent... fighting out of the blue corner and representing *Savage Wolf MMA*... with a perfect record of nine knockout victories and no losses... from Washington, Missouri... 'The Lioness of Iron Mountain'... JilliAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAN GRAAAAAACE!"

The who of WHAT?

I guess we knew which corner the ring announcer was in, and he was far from alone. Not only had Grace's early triumphs gathered her a sizable fan club, but even those who had no particular affiliation took an interest in this one. Dove's stunning finish had been a momentary treat, and Liv's battle with Walcott had exceeded expectations by a long shot. But overall, this had been a night of mostly lackluster matchups between inexperienced fighters. The crowd was ready for something big, and the roar that accompanied Grace's entrance told me that watching the blonde beauty knock Zendaya around the cage was exactly what they were looking for.

Jillian, meanwhile, did an excellent job of looking like a fighter who expected to win. Barely acknowledging the fans, she moved toward the cage like... well, like a lioness on the prowl. Long, sleek, confident strides carried her along at a pace her team had to practically run to keep up with. Once inside the octagon, she moved directly to her corner without so much as a glance at our group.

In all, she looked like she just wanted this over with. Like it was an inconvenience for her to even be here.

Autumn Reeser was once again wearing the stripes, and she called the fighters out for their instructions. With Grace in the cage, there was a tremendous flurry of activity as the media photographers snapped away. Again, she was ready for the show... standing tall and menacing as she stared lasers into her younger opponent. But Z, being the skilled actress she is, was up for her role, as well. Because it would be impossible to look as bored as she did without practice.

The fighters retreated and, with the crowd hungry for action, Reeser wasted no time calling for the bell.

Grace wasted no time either - skipping the usual pawing and prancing and going right after it with a left hook.

The surprise attack fell just short as Daya managed to lean back out of danger at the last second. The dodge was far from smooth, and it left her out of position to take advantage of the miss. But she tried anyway, pressing forward awkwardly behind her jab. Grace stood her ground, and the two exchanged punches near the center of the cage. Daya showed good hand speed which allowed her to get the better of the skirmish - landing a solid right hand that forced Grace to back out.

Gaining confidence, Z kept after her with a hook to the body. It was a ill-conceived idea from the word go. Jillian's defense was composed and elegant as she neatly side-stepped the attack while putting herself in perfect position for the counter. Meanwhile, Daya committed herself completely. The miss left her wide open, and Jillian Grace immediately did what she does best.

A right hand opened the assault as it slammed into the side of Coleman's head, and Grace was quick to follow.

Left hook, right hook.

Daya blocked the left by accident as her guard came up automatically, but the right got through - hitting nearly the same spot as the previous shot.

Grace never stopped punching as she turned her attention downstairs with another left, right combo.

Daya took both vicious shots and threw it in full reverse as she tried to get out of range. But Jillian stayed right with her, throwing the whole way. It wasn't long before Z felt the fence at her back.

Even the greenest of rookies knows that getting caught against the cage is as bad as it gets, and Coleman immediately let loose with a flurry of punches as she tried to fight her way out. Again, her hand speed won the showdown as she backed Grace off enough to circle away. But Jillian got her pound of flesh - feeding her younger opponent another big right hand on the way out.

Back at center, Daya looked uncomfortable. Thrown off by how quickly the first significant exchange had gone to hell... and maybe something more? She certainly seemed out of rhythm.

Electing to go on the attack, she tried to sneak in a low kick before Jillian could set. It missed but still served to get the blonde fighter backing up, making room for Coleman to push forward.

Jab, cross, hook.

The combination was sharp and fast, but Grace had no trouble with it as she casually blocked and stepped away.

Daya stayed on her with more fast combinations. Then, as they neared the fence, Z surged forward behind the one-two and tried to grapple.

Grace saw the clinch coming and got her arms underneath, taking what's known as the underhook position.

Without pausing, the blonde lifted her arm. That, in turn, pushed Daya's up as well. Coleman instinctively countered by trying to force the arm back down and level herself off, but the move shifted her balance slightly. Just the way Jillian wanted. The brief moment of unevenness made it easy for her to spin her opponent and reverse their positions.

Z had gone from having the advantage to being in deep trouble in less than five seconds.

At first, it looked like things might be okay. Despite being crushed against the mesh, Daya stayed cool as she methodically tried to work out of it. But it turned out Grace was just biding her time... casually working to get the position she wanted. Once she was satisfied, she let the punches fly.

Jab, cross, hook.

The close-quarters didn't seem to matter much, as Grace did a great job of getting her weight behind the strikes. The cross did the most damage... crushing Zendaya's head straight back into the fence. The brunette was clearly hurt, and she immediately turtled up behind her guard. Just like Jillian wanted. The hook landed harmlessly on Coleman's shoulder, but Grace finished the combo with a monstrous uppercut. Z never saw it coming, and the force of the blow knocked her clean off her feet.

Grace rushed forward looking to mount, but Daya was quick to get her feet up in a defensive position. The blonde decided not to chance it and backed off. Seeing this, Z wasted no time regaining her feet.

As strange as it seemed, the move made sense because Grace was not known for her work on the ground. Pummeling a helpless opponent to get the finish was one thing, but she didn't want to get tangled up down there with someone who could fight back. Standing was where she was most comfortable, and she'd been pretty effective so far in this fight. No need to take risks. Just stick with what's working.

The RSI fighter put her guard up and prepared to wade back into the fray. Despite the pounding and the knockdown, she seemed ready and willing to fight on... but looked even more uncomfortable than before. I had the sense that something was going wrong. That something she was looking for or trying to do wasn't happening, and she didn't know what to do about it.

She got her stance set and focused on her opponent. Then she immediately proved she was far from done, connecting with a right that snapped Grace's head straight back.

With Grace having never faced a serious challenge, there was a theory out there that she might not last very long once someone hit her back. But that possibility died pretty fast as she shook off Z's punch and answered with a bone shattering right of her own.

The RSI fighter stumbled from the impact and Jillian ran in to capitalize with a series of combinations. Daya gathered her guard quickly - blocking well as she looked for angles to counter. No luck. Jillian was going all out, and Z had trouble seeing through the blizzard of punches - many of which began to find their mark. With no other choice, Daya was forced to make a stand and fire blindly into the face of Grace's assault.

As expected, it did little good. Jillian calmly leaned away to avoid Daya's strikes, then found a hole and launched another strong right hand that landed with a loud smack and sent the TV crew into a frenzy.

Coleman stopped that one with her face! How is she still standing?

It was a damn good question. Though many questions remained unanswered regarding Jillian, her fearsome power was well-known. That last punch was as clean and crisp as any I'd seen. The kind of thing that would stop a charging rhino. But Daya somehow took it and stayed in the fight... quickly snapping her guard in place as she backed away.

Grace chased after her with another flurry of combinations. Daya hung tough - weathering the attack, then surging forward behind her jab. Pushing deep inside of Grace's defenses. It was soon clear that she was once again looking to grapple.

The blonde got her hands out and seemed to welcome the challenge. As the two battled, again it was Grace who got the better position.

Daya fought back, firing away with body shots. But Grace controlled the angle, and the punches went nowhere. Then Jillian retaliated with another vicious combo, punctuated by that same savage uppercut.

CRACK!

Daya dropped like a rock.

That one almost breaks Zendaya's chin! Coleman is down AGAIN!

This one looked bad, and I could see Reeser was on alert. Ready to jump in at any second.

At cageside, I saw Steph rubbing her forehead in frustration. Just like Z, she looked unsettled, and now I knew for sure something was wrong. Whatever plan she'd sent her fighter in there with obviously wasn't working. And at the rate this was going, she wasn't going to get the chance to fix it.

Daya was clearly dazed, and Grace quickly took advantage... dropping a brutal knee into the younger fighter's belly.

I thought that was it. The brunette had offered no defense to the knee attack, and Grace was now inches from securing the mount. Reeser was going to have to stop this.

But then Z came alive... squirming out from under as the blonde tried to get positioned for the finish. Grace tried to stay with her, but Daya spun on her back then punished her opponent with a terrific upkick.

Jillian stumbled a few steps before she could halt her momentum. More pissed than hurt, she shot a vicious glare Coleman's way. Then she waited. Motioning with her hand. Daring Daya to get up.

Not one to look a gift horse in the mouth, Daya stood and tried to gather herself. No easy task because she was a mess. Her face was puffy and swollen from the blows she'd taken, and blood was running from a cut beneath her right eye.

Taking punches from the likes of Jillian Grace will do that to you.

The blonde surged forward. With less than fifteen seconds left in the round, she was in a rush to finish the job.

A looping left hand crashed into the brunette's chin, stunning her again. She kept her guard up but a right from Grace slipped between her gloves and found its mark. Daya punched back - mostly as a defensive reflex - but she could barely see what she was swinging at through Jillian's attacks. Still, she stood her ground. Amazingly - though Grace definitely got the best of the exchange - Z was still upright when the bell sounded.

I blew out a long sigh as I looked up into the rafters - unsure if I should be relieved Zendaya had survived or horrified that she was only a minute away from having to march back out and do it all again.

"Well, that was ugly," I said aloud.

Danni didn't even bother with a response.

* * *

The first thing I noticed was the way Steph looked when the bell sounded. There was only one word to describe it: disgusted. Something had gone terribly wrong, and it looked to me like she was about to give Daya and earful over it. But then she wiped the expression away as she followed Marcy and Emily into the cage.

Marcy quickly assessed the injury situation and found her spot. Emily took a complementary position, allowing the Nordic magician to get to work.

Daya looked frustrated and angry. Despite some brief flashes, she'd done little other than get her ass kicked so far. But instead of getting in her face over it, Steph surprisingly took ownership of the whole mess.

Twice in five seconds, I saw her emphatically touch a hand to her own chest.

That's on me, the gesture said.

Daya's expression didn't change. She was flat out pissed. At Steph? At Grace? At herself? It was hard to say, but my guess was a little bit of each.

Steph got more animated, slashing her arm through the air.

Forget it. We lost that round. Let's get the next one.

Emily got involved, also urging the younger fighter to put that one behind her.

"That doesn't look good," I said.

"Wouldn't you be a little upset if you were her?" Danni replied.

No. After a round like that, I would be totally enraged.

"She's gotta shake it off," I said.

She shrugged as if to say, *Well, we'll see.*

In the cage, Steph waited for a response. Emily prodded again. After a few seconds, Daya grudgingly signaled her agreement with a little nod and Steph launched into whatever Plan B was.

I was pretty sure I knew what had gone wrong. All of Grace's previous fights had come to a sudden and vicious end in very short order. With practically no film to study, Steph was left to formulate a plan from scratch and it was now obvious what she'd come up with. The one thing that was known about Jillian was that she liked to stay at distance and let the big punches fly, so Steph had obviously told Coleman not to let that happen. That's why Daya kept looking for the clinch. Steph had told her to tie things up and see if Grace could fight inside.

The bad news was that she could, and she was better at it than Z was.

The good news - if you could call it that - was that Daya had now lasted six times longer than any of Jillian's previous opponents, despite taking a whole slew of tremendous blows from the powerful blonde. Say what you want, the kid didn't suffer from a glass jaw.

I looked back to Steph and realized she had gone silent. Instead, she had ceded the moment to Emily, who was now talking a mile a minute.

I tried to think of a time when I'd seen Steph give up the reins before and came up empty. There are occasions when she is unavailable - usually because she has a fight of her own to prepare for - and others have to step in to fill her role. With all of her experience and success, Emily is certainly prominent among those others. But when Steph is there, it's her show. Period. I had no idea why she was taking a back seat this time.

Daya stood as the break wound down, and I got my first good look at the results of the repair work. Marcy had managed to stop the bleeding and slow the swelling, but, despite her many skills, there simply was no way to reverse what had been done. But it didn't appear Z would have any vision problems as a result of the damage. Thank god for small blessings.

Physical damage aside, Daya looked significantly better as far as her attitude went. Whatever Emily was saying, it was having an impact.

As Em finished her instructions, Steph retook control and became insistent - even cupping a hand under Daya's chin to force her to look at her.

You can DO this!

Daya nodded.

Emily added another shot of encouragement.

Daya nodded more firmly, and I could tell they'd gotten through to her. Despite the disastrous first round, she looked like a fighter who believed in what her team was telling her. Whatever the new plan was, she had confidence that she could make it work.

"What now?" I asked Danni.

She thought about it for a minute. Searching for any answer other than the one we both knew was right.

"I think they have to let her square up," she said finally.

I nodded absently. It was not an ingenious strategy, but it was really the only option.

Trying to neutralize Jillian hadn't worked at all. Worse, Daya's inexperience showed through in the way she kept trying anyway - unable to adjust on the fly. So, there was no way they were going to send her out there to explore some other theory. The goal now would be to keep things as simple as possible.

With no known weaknesses to exploit and no real information to go on, the only play was to go straight at the problem. To try to succeed where nine other fighters had spectacularly failed.

Zendaya was going to have to go toe-to-toe with the Golden Child.

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Aside from looking like she'd had the crap kicked out of her, I liked what I saw in Daya's posture as the bell rang to start the second. Her chin was down and her eyes were up. Her movement seemed steadier and more natural.

None of that gave Jillian any pause, though. She came out looking confident to the point of arrogance. She was likely a little pissed, too. The queen of the quick and brutal knockout forced into a second round? Unthinkable. Just by standing there, Coleman was chipping away at the aura of the great Jillian Grace.

But give her credit... she didn't lose her form in an attempt to make a point. Stance set, guard up, eyes alert and calculating. She kept her focus on getting the win. No matter how long it took.

Daya, on the other hand, seemed to jump the gun. As soon as Grace even got close, she fired off the jab. It was too soon, and the punch fell well short of the goal.

No harm done as Z circled away before her opponent could respond. But then, as the distance between them closed, she did it again. A double-jab this time, thrown just as Grace stepped into range. The blonde easily backed out, and the punches went nowhere.

The cycle repeated twice more before Grace got sick of it and decided she'd had enough.

As Z flashed the jab, Jillian pawed it aside and responded with a picture perfect right hand. It was a well-timed counter, thrown crisply with excellent form.

And it fell short.

Despite the fact that the blonde had stepped into the punch, Zendaya only had to lean away slightly to avoid it. The full extension left Grace open, and Coleman came right in behind as Jillian drew her hand back and tried to regroup.

Jab, cross, hook.

The first two punches zipped in clean before Grace was able to gather her defense. She caught enough of the hook to save herself further damage, then lashed out with her jab to back her opponent off of her.

Too late. Z was already long gone.

Both fighters reset, then came together again near the center of the cage. Daya led off with yet another jab to nowhere. Grace moved to counter, came up short, and then it was Z's turn again.

Bap, Bap!

She popped the older fighter with the one-two again, then circled away before Grace could respond.

The blonde stalked after her. Daya flashed the jab and hit nothing. Jillian appeared to briefly think about countering, then decided against it and backed away.

Another reset and the blonde waded back in quickly. Daya stuck the jab out again. Grace easily avoided it as she couched low - poised to strike. But again she didn't seem comfortable and the counterattack never came.

And that's when I understood why Z kept throwing punches that had no hope of landing. She was doing what she'd been told to do. Keeping things as simple as simple could be. Rather than focusing on the many areas where Jillian had the advantage, this was all about the one statistic that clearly fell on Daya's side of the ledger.

Inches.

Five of them, to be exact. Because, while Grace might be a smart, powerful, talented fighter, no amount of experience or training was ever going to make her taller.

That's why Z kept poking out her jab. To let Grace know. *I can reach you before you can reach me.* To get her thinking about having to find a way around to get inside.

The blonde had already tried simple countering but misjudged the range. As a result, Z had slapped her around a bit. No real harm done, but it meant Grace needed a better strategy. And all this looking and peeking and retreating was telling me she didn't have one.

The trial and error approach went on for nearly a minute, with Grace unable to decide on the best route to get at her opponent. Then she got tired of playing around and chose the shortest possible distance.

The blonde came straight in with her guard up high. Daya shot the jab, which bounced harmlessly off of Jillian's arm. Grace kept coming. No flash or artistry to it. Just straight on like a mindless robot. A sitting duck for any one of a dozen attacks Daya could launch. Only she didn't because she wasn't ready. She'd expected more of the same. For Grace to shy away from the jab. She realized her mistake and fired off the right hand, but it was too late. Grace was already inside and the punch glanced harmlessly off her guard.

Jab, hook.

Grace flustered Daya with the left, then buried her right in the younger fighter's gut.

Z bit down hard as Jillian's glove fist slammed into her unprotected belly... enough so that I caught a clear flash of the red mouthguard between her teeth even from way up here.

Cross, hook.

Grace gave no quarter as she moved upstairs and forced a right hand into the brunette's face. The hook that followed missed only because the right had already sent Daya reeling.

After a few steps of uncontrolled stumbling, she gathered herself and quickly circled back and away before Grace could attack again. Once she put some space between them, she stole a *that was close* glance at her team standing at cageside.

Steph was stoic to the point of looking disinterested. Probably because she didn't want to pull any attention away from Emily, who was shouting for all she was worth. I obviously couldn't hear a word, but I saw her point emphatically at the floor over and over again.

The meaning was a mystery to me, and, to be honest, I didn't think it mattered. Directions screamed from cageside rarely register with a fighter in the heat of the battle. So I was shocked when I saw Daya give a tight little nod to indicate the message was received.

I still had no clue what was going on, but I was now certain Steph had done the right thing in yielding to Emily. Whatever strategy she was coaching, her pupil was clearly tuned in.

The two fighters squared off and sized each other up. Daya stuck the jab out again, but Grace was unfazed - flashing her own jab then advancing behind it.

THUMP!

As soon as the blonde moved forward, Z's foot hit her in the chest. A quick, sharp strike thrown without any sort of windup or weight shift. Though short on power, it stopped the blonde's forward march cold.

Grace looked surprised and more than a little annoyed at the way the impact halted her advance. Still, it had done little damage, so she shrugged it off and reset her stance.

Again Z made the first move, pushing out her lengthy jab. Grace waited, gauged the distance, then made her move.

THUMP!

The blonde had barely moved an inch before Daya stopped her in her tracks with the kick again.

It happened five more times... each a repetition so exact that it became comical. No matter what Grace tried - jabs, combos... even some kicks of her own - she could not reach Daya from the outside and she couldn't come forward without running into the brunette's foot.

The weapon Z was deploying was called a *teep kick*. A staple of the Muay Thai fighting style, it is not nearly as easy as she was making it look. Getting it right requires two major components.

First, split-second reflexes. Your opponent moves, you kick instantly. Too slow and she'll be in too close for you to extend.

Second, rigid attention to detail. You had to lift your leg and kick straight out. No laziness or slacking off. A good opponent will be thinking about catching your foot. If they succeed, you're screwed. To prevent that, the kick has to be done right - sharp and straight and high. So that - even if she got a hand on it - the jarring upper-body impact would drive her back and make it extremely difficult to hang on. But get sloppy and let your foot drop, and it's a whole different story.

How do I know all this? Because I recently learned it from RSI's queen of the *kick first* approach. The same woman who just so happened to be standing cageside at this very moment, screaming her pretty little head off.

Down on the floor, both camps were shouting in at their fighters. Grace's corner was trying to calm her down and help her figure out how to get to her opponent. Emily was telling Z to keep it up, while probably also giving her ideas on how to take things up a notch.

Jillian wasn't getting the message. She was putting in a lot of effort, getting zero return and totally losing her patience. If anything, her situation was going downhill as she was now dancing around just outside of her opponent's range. Reluctant to come forward and run into the kick.

As for Zendaya, I could visibly see her reacting to what Emily was saying. Giving little nods and quick glances, while never losing track of her opponent.

"Are you seeing this?" I asked Danni.

"I am."

"And what do you make of it?"

"It's weird," she said. "I guess..."

She fished around for an answer for a while, then shrugged.

"There's no prep for this thing," she said. "They're creating strategy on the fly, and Z knows she needs help. So, it's crazy, but it's working, I guess."

I could do nothing but nod. While it was definitely unorthodox, it was also a big step up from the disastrous results of the first round.

In the cage, Grace tried taking a different tack. She padded out her jab, started forward behind it then immediately stopped. A feint to deliberately bait Coleman into throwing the teep, which she did. As Daya drew her foot back, Jillian followed it and came forward for real. By the time Z was set, it was too late to throw the teep again. A problem? Nope. She immediately shot her jab into her advancing opponent and circled left. Grace guarded the jab easily, but when she went to respond with an attack of her own, she found no one there to hit. Daya was gone.

Z stole another glance at her team. Emily was shouting emphatically again as she held two fingers up beside her head.

Two! Two! Two!

Again I was clueless, but Daya appeared to understand.

Though her strategy had come to nothing, Grace was encouraged that the feint had at least gotten her inside. She tried again, and Daya took the bait and threw a teep that fell short. Grace came forward, more determined this time. But Daya's counter was more determined, as well. Out came the jab, with the cross right behind it. Jillian stopped the jab, then immediately moved to launch an attack before her opponent could escape again. That opened a huge hole for Z's right hand to sail through, her thinly-padded fist slamming nearly dead center into the blonde's face.

Grace backpedaled and actually shook her head to clear the effects of the impact.

A quick turn of her head gave Z another view of Emily, who was now slapping her hand against her left thigh.

Grace got her bearings and closed. Daya threw the teep without even waiting for the feint. Grace moved into range with her guard high and Daya immediately attacked.

Jab, cross, hook kick.

The strikes came as a set. Quickly and without hesitation. The blonde kept her guard up and absorbed both punches. Then - just as she stole a peek to see if more was coming - Daya's left foot buried itself in her side.

I looked again at Emily, who was now crossing and uncrossing her arms out in front of her. Like a football official signaling a missed field goal.

If her previous signals made no sense to me, then I had no hope of figuring this one out. But the overall picture was finally starting to take shape.

"*On the fly*, my ass," I said.

"It's some kind of system," Danni agreed. "Emily is calling plays."

The two fingers meant throw two punches instead of one. The leg tap was a call to add the kick.

"So, what the fuck does that one mean?" I asked.

"Let's watch and find out."

The two fighters met again at the center of the cage. They danced around each other for a while - both looking for angles. Daya raised her leg for the teep, then strangely dropped her foot without throwing it.

"Fake," Danni and I said in unison.

This time it was Z laying out bait, and Grace swallowed it hook, line and sinker. Jillian saw the aborted kick as an opening and pushed forward - right into perfect range. Z's foot bounced back up immediately and out popped the teep, strong and long. Coupled with the momentum of Grace's confident surge, the impact knocked the blonde clean off her feet.

Z briefly gave chase, but the older fighter quickly scrambled back to standing.

Though the knockdown was embarrassing, Jillian didn't appear too hurt. In fact, despite all the success Daya was having in this round, she really hadn't done much damage. But right now, this was more of a mental battle than a physical one. Being constantly kicked away was very obviously starting to wear on Grace. More importantly, her smug, confident countenance was gone, replaced by a look of frustration and confusion. So far, Daya had spent this round reminding everyone - including her opponent - that the great

Jillian Grace was still a rookie. One who had never been faced with the kind of strategy she was seeing now, and it was very clear she had no idea what to do about it.

Daya glanced back to cageside. Danni and I did the same. Emily had her left hand up in front of her and she was using her middle and index fingers to point at her eyes.

"Use your laser vision?" I guessed.

"I..."

Danni stopped cold as she processed what I'd said. Then she turned and stared at the side of my head. A full five seconds of stunned silence passed.

"Well, what do YOU think it means?" I asked as I turned to her.

She shook her head in disapproval, but offered no better theory.

Z got herself squared away as Grace closed again. Daya faked the teep but the blonde didn't bite. Another moment or two of circling, then Z threw the teep for real. It fell short, and Grace moved in behind it. The RSI fighter reloaded and got the leg up for another teep. Realizing she was caught in a bad spot, Jillian stopped her advance and got her guard down - ready for impact. Daya dropped her foot. It had been another fake. Now Grace was standing flat-footed in front of her with her guard too low. Daya shot the jab - which both scored and brought the blonde's guard up. Without pause, Z pivoted and drove her right foot into the blonde's side. Though the blow clearly did damage, Grace willed past it and tried to score some points of her own with a straight right hand, but her opponent was already out of range and backing away.

Another check showed Emily was doing the eye thing again. I still didn't know what it meant, but I found the initial results promising.

I glanced at the clock. Less than a minute to go in the round.

Grace gamely came forward again, but she was all sorts of discombobulated now. Should she press forward? Feint? Wait for Z to make a move?

The end result was more dancing just outside of Zendaya's kill zone. Constant circling, some feinting and an occasional swing and miss, but nothing of any substance. Z, meanwhile, did an excellent job of staying square with her opponent and maintaining the distance between them. Determined to keep the fight on her terms.

Again, it was Jillian's patience that wore out first.

The blonde feinted forward and Z drew her leg up. Grace hesitated, then rushed forward. Z dropped her leg and instead of playing dodge and counter, she surged into her attacking opponent.

Jab, knee.

The jab caught Grace again and brought her guard up, just in time for Z to sink a knee into her gut. Jillian responded again with the right hand, but scored only a glancing blow as Coleman circled away and stole another quick look to cageside.

Em was nodding as she pointed again.

"She's turned her loose," Danni said.

I nodded absently. The constant pointing wasn't meant to convey a specific tactic. It was a reminder that Daya already knew what to do.

Emily wasn't teaching the younger fighter anything here tonight. That was done back at the RSI facility. Em had shared quite a bit of knowledge over these past few months, and Daya clearly absorbed much of it. But this was the first time she'd tried to use what she learned in a real battle, and it hadn't started out very smoothly. That's what we'd been seeing. Emily coaching her pupil through a rough start, using the strategies and attacks they had already practiced.

Up until now, each gesture had conveyed a specific thought.

Remember when we did this? Now's the time to use it.

But the pointing... that carried a much broader message.

You've got this, now. Stay alert. Watch her. You know what to do.

A display of confidence, but also a reminder to stay the course. While this had not been a good round for Grace, she was not badly hurt. Now was not the time for Daya to take risks and launch an all out assault. Jillian was confused and frustrated, and she was responding poorly. Pressing and making mistakes. Playing right into Z's hands. There was no reason for Coleman to change tactics, but there was also no way to predict what Grace might do next. So Emily was trusting her young protégé to read and react accordingly, but also consistently reminding her to stay vigilant.

Daya had proven up to the task so far, but, with twenty seconds left in the round, Grace finally found a way.

The two were circling left with Grace staying just out of range. Then the blonde suddenly switched directions, stepping back to her right. Z did likewise and raised her foot for the teep. Grace changed directions again, stepping left as she surged forward. Daya popped the teep but - because of Grace's lateral movement - she only got a small piece of the blonde's side. Jillian, meanwhile, finally had a clear lane.

Left hook, uppercut.

Daya was badly out position and Grace's aim was true. Both punches hit home and it was immediately clear that Coleman was hurt. She retreated and pulled her head down behind her guard. Grace went to the body...

first the left hook, then the right. Daya's guard came down - just as Jillian knew it would - and now the same two punches sailed in head-high. Z's head whipped left, then right. She stumbled and backpedaled and Grace practically ran after her to finish her off. Coleman blundered into the fence, and you could almost see Jillian salivating.

DING!

Reeser jumped in to separate the two as the bell sounded to end the round.

I exhaled loudly as I looked up into the rafters again.

"Ohhhh... my god," Danni moaned as she ran a hand through her hair.

Though the round had been completely different, it had ended exactly the same way the first one had. With Z lucky to still be standing upright.

* * *

Two rounds down, one to go, and I didn't like the look of things at all. Though the judges had probably leaned Z's way in the second, the near disaster at the end meant there was no guarantee. And Grace had clearly taken the first in a landslide. Even if Daya could control the upcoming final round, there was no way to say for sure how a decision might go. She would need a decisive performance - or an even more decisive finish - if she was going to win this thing.

There was no wasted time for the RSI team this time around. Steph went over and nonchalantly helped Daya to the corner, where Marcy and Emily were already waiting. With no new open wounds to tend to, the Nordic magician went right to work on the swelling - knowing she had a much better chance of controlling it this time since Grace hadn't done any real damage until the end of the round.

I was so busy watching Marcy work, that it took me nearly ten seconds to realize that it was Emily standing in front of Coleman this time while Steph had taken on the role of assisting RSI's cut specialist.

Danni and I looked at each other.

"How is it that, no matter how much credit I give her, I constantly underestimate Steph?" I asked.

Danni just shook her head and gave a *what can I tell you?* shrug.

The connection between Emily and Zendaya was now blatantly obvious. Rather than trying to become part of that, Steph had gotten completely out of the way. Some might see that as her admitting failure. I saw it as her doing her job better than ever. Daya needed Em right now, and Steph wasn't going to let some arbitrary pecking order interfere with that. Instead, she did what she always does. Focus on what was in the best interest of her fighter. And so she had handed the reins over to Em and then gotten down on one knee and started handling water bottles and washing spit and blood off of mouthpieces.

Not only was it the right thing to do, but I was absolutely certain it had been entirely Steph's idea.

Emily, meanwhile, was right in Z's face. Not yelling. Coaching. Throwing imaginary punches. Slapping her elbows to remind her pupil that she could use those too. Mostly though, she was pointing down. Telling Daya to remember that her feet were her greatest weapon.

There were a lot of ways to look at this situation. I think many might feel that Z had already scored an enormous victory. After all, no one really believed she even stood a prayer when this had started, but she had lasted two full rounds and had definitely done much more than merely survive. She had stood nose-to-nose with Grace for the entirety of the second, and had owned most of the round. It was a performance to be proud of, but every look Em gave and every move she made delivered a much different message. A message that said, *I don't want to hear about moral victories. I believe in you and I know you can WIN this thing.*

As the break wound down, she grabbed Z's chin in much the same way Steph had earlier. She didn't say a word. Just gave a firm, resolute nod that Daya immediately returned.

All I could do was shake my head. Steph had been absolutely right earlier. While I was busy being encouraged by the way the rookies were getting along with their veteran counterparts, I had failed to see that something truly amazing was happening within the walls of *Rampage Sports*. They weren't just getting along. They were getting together. Teaming up and getting involved in each other. Nowhere was that more apparent than in the scene unfolding in that cage right now. Prior to Zendaya being forced to haul Emily's bag a few months ago, I couldn't recall seeing the two so much as speak to each other. Now they looked like life-long comrades, marching into battle together.

Maybe that was the deal. *Carry my bags rookie, and I'll carry YOU.*

Regardless, I now found myself wanting this for both of them. It would be the fitting result. The one they both deserved. But in the cage, you don't get what you deserve.

You get what you go out there and take.

* * *

The most aggravating thing about the way the previous round ended was what it did for Grace's mental state. For nearly the entire round, she had been frustrated, angry and confused. Then, with only seconds left, she had come within inches of putting Daya out of her misery. Another ten seconds, and this one would have been all over.

The confidence boost that had given her was obvious as the final round got underway. Once again, she was dancing just out of Daya's range, but there was nothing tentative or uncertain about the way she was moving. Every move she made seemed deliberate. She would surge and feint, then back away. Quick sudden movements designed to get Z to show the teep. And it was working. Daya's foot was bouncing up and down like a yo-yo, and she actually threw the kick several times without hitting anything. All of this

was data for Jillian to compute. A way for her to get comfortable with Z's movement and her timing on the kick.

Once she had the feel, she made her move.

Again, it started with a quick step to her right. Z turned to square and popped the teep, but Grace had immediately slipped back to the left. The kick missed right and Jillian moved in, hands up high. Daya stuck her jab out, but Grace guarded it aside and hit her with a big left hook.

Daya was already sliding away to her left, which helped to lessen the impact. Still it was a solid punch that did real damage.

Once she was safely out of range, Zendaya stole a look at her mentor. I noticed the broadcast feed seemed to continually find Em between exchanges now, as well. Apparently, someone with a brain had clued the TV people into the peculiar dynamic between the young rookie and RSI's most decorated lightweight, and they were watching as closely as we were.

Right now, it showed her miming an aggressive sweeping punch across her body with her left hand.

"She wants her to counter into the gap," Danni translated.

It was a basic law of fight physics. If your opponent's movement opens a window for her to punch into, it also gives you a place to put your counter. If Z could keep her positioning and react quickly enough, she could get there first.

Of course, the downside of that is what could happen if the counter didn't land. It was a lesson Daya was about to be reminded of in a very painful way.

The next exchange started with Grace moving right again. Z raised the teep, but wasn't as quick to bite. Focused on maintaining crucial balance and positioning that left her better prepared when Grace changed direction. Jillian moved in and Z tried to counter with the left hand, but the punch was slow and tentative. Worse than that, the miss gave away that balance she'd been so careful to protect and Grace caught her flat-footed with another big left hook. There was no lessening the impact of this one. It caught her flush on the cheek and it was followed immediately by a wicked right hand that drove Daya straight back. The younger fighter retreated, stumbling and tripping on the way out, but managing to get clear before more damage could be done.

Daya looked more than a little frazzled. Emily was gesturing mightily with the left again, imploring her to throw the counter more confidently.

Grace came forward again and offered a few feints that Daya refused to bite on. Then she did the right-left slip and in she came. Instead of being more emphatic, Z's counter was a disastrous, half-hearted mess because she was already in full retreat before she threw it. The early fall back worked in that she got out of danger before Grace could get to her, but it gave off the terrible impression of running away. The kind of thing that was guaranteed to lose her this fight.

At cageside, Emily - perhaps realizing her fighter was coming unglued - was going with a whole new approach. Quieting her movements, save for a steady palms-down gesture with both hands.

This one was universally recognizable.

Alright, settle down.

Amazingly, the gesture appeared to work. Only seconds ago, Daya looked so unnerved as to be on the verge of panic. But now she settled back into her stance and seemed to quickly find a rhythm.

I'd never seen anything like it. It looked like Z was actually feeding off her mentor's emotional state.

"OK, what in the hell is happening here?" I asked.

Danni looked equally mystified, but took a shot at explaining anyway.

"She's a smart kid," she said of Zendaya. "She obviously trusts Emily, and it's gotten her this far. Why stop now?"

Emily's gesturing became slower, but more emphatic. Soothing, but also staunchly supportive.

You know what you need to do, and we both know you can.

In truth, there was no choice now. No time to mix in some new tactic or idea. Daya was already behind and Grace was getting the better of her again in this round. She needed to turn things around, and the first thing she needed to do was put a stop to the way her opponent was outmaneuvering her.

To do it, she was going to have to do more than trust Emily. She was going to have to trust herself.

And now would be a good time to figure it out because Jillian was coming again.

The two fighters circled near the center of the ring, both looking for angles. Grace was looking supremely confident for all the reasons I just mentioned. Despite suffering her biggest scare to date, she was now controlling the cage once more. Instead of a letdown, this would be a feather in her cap. After so many quick and easy wins, she had faced a true challenge and still come out on top.

Now, if she could only get her younger opponent to stand and fight her so she could go for the big finish.

She stepped right again - a move Daya still had to honor despite knowing it was likely a fake - then slid immediately left and went on the attack.

BOOM!

Rather than giving ground, Z had planted and fired as soon as she was sure Grace was coming. Exactly what Emily had wanted. Not a defensive jab. A heavy, confident, perfectly-timed left hand thrown across her body and into the lane Grace was trying to come through - catching her just as she was surging forward.

The resulting impact was spectacular.

A halo of sweat sprayed from Grace's head as the punch crushed her face. Her left knee momentarily buckled, then she staggered in that direction with her head leading the rest of her body. It was hard to tell just how much of her faltering was the simple shock of getting caught with the counter and how much was her being truly hurt.

Two seconds later it didn't matter.

Daya - who clearly knew that it was now or never - had stayed in her stance and walked the reeling blonde down. Ready to pounce on any opportunity she saw. That opportunity came when Jillian got her feet under her and started to gather her defense. Z never gave her the chance. With one last step she slid left, planted her lead leg and spun... bringing her right foot off the canvas. Her momentum merged with the power generated by her leg. The kick sailed cleanly over Grace's meager guard and exploded just below the blonde's left ear.

The classic high kick. The move we'd seen Emily end so many fights with, now executed to perfection by her young pupil. Simple, yet effective... there is no way to overestimate the damage it can do. As in, if it hits you squarely, you are done.

Such was the case for the previously undefeated Jillian Grace.

The blonde fell over in a heap, and Reeser was there immediately. Covering the prone fighter with her body while shouting for Z to back off.

Daya recovered her stance like a veteran. Her leg retracted and the foot touched back down to the canvas... perfectly spread from its mate. Hands up and ready for more.

She stayed like that for a few seconds. Frozen in her combative pose. Like an ancient warrior, serenely overlooking her fallen rival after a great battle.

Then she slowly realized what she'd done and turned to Emily and Steph with a look that asked, *Are you fucking kidding me?*

Both veterans gave her a smile and a little *be cool* gesture as they worked their way into the cage behind Grace's team. Once through the door, Emily went immediately to Z. The two touched foreheads as the teacher quietly praised her young pupil in a genuinely heartwarming scene. Then Marcy broke it up as she abruptly shouldered her way in to check Daya's condition.

I guess you can add *nor touching moment of victory* to that list of things that don't slow Marcy down.

Up in the box, Danni and I were both smiling broadly.

"Three-for-three," I said. "They all won."

True, a couple of them had done it by the skin of their teeth. But a win is a win, and it was a damn fine improvement over their past performances.

"Once again, RSI shows what it's made of," she said with an authentic note of superiority.

That kind of prideful boasting didn't fit at all with her personality or the personality of the stable she leads. But given the circumstances, it was more than warranted. This wasn't a win for a single fighter or even three. It was a victory for the entire organization.

The medics had just gotten Grace to her feet when the announcer's voice started in on the official announcement, but we didn't stay around to hear it.

We had someplace we needed to be.

* * *

By the time we reached the RSI locker room, every member of the stable was gathered in the back. Zendaya was holed up in one of training rooms being assessed by the medical staff, and her fellow rookies were apparently in there with her. I didn't really understand how that happened, but I wasn't worried. If they got in the way, Trish would calmly open the door and unceremoniously boot them into the hall.

I guess everyone behaved themselves because no such corrective action was required. All three emerged together when the door opened a few minutes later, and they were immediately swarmed by their teammates as a deafening roar erupted in the locker room. Britney and Elisha wasted no time getting to Z, with Brit catching the youngest member of the middleweight group in a headlock while Leesh gave her what I believe is technically known as a noogie. Emily was there too, standing a discreet distance from the fray while shaking her head in mock disapproval. Jules threw her arms around Dove, with Jen Morrison standing by waiting for her turn. Tiz slung an arm over Liv's shoulder while Emma reached out and tousled the younger fighter's blonde locks.

Danni and I paused to check in with Trish and Marcy. All good. Liv and Zendaya would need to go through the full concussion protocol as a precaution, but neither were showing any significant signs of trouble.

With that established, Danni took a few steps toward Liv, who saw her coming and practically launched herself into her stable leader's arms.

For the time being, I sort of hung off to the side. I wanted to run over and pull all three young fighters into a big hug. To congratulate them and tell them how proud I was. Then I wanted to drag them into a room and show them some video. To take each one and run tonight's performance side-by-side with her last fight. Let them see just how far they'd come in such a short time.

But all of that would have to wait because I couldn't even get close to them. Their teammates had them now, and there would be no prying them loose. The party was on.

Welcome to the family, kids.